

City Hall speaks

Boston's new City Hall, opened in 1968, is probably the single most honored and discussed American building of its era.

A poll a couple of years ago, sponsored by the American Institute of Architects, rated City Hall the eighth "most significant" building in American History.

Much has been written about it. Most of that has focused on the urban renewal process, under Ed Logue, that created it, or the national competition to choose the design, or on how well the building functions (or fails to), or how it works in the cityscape, or where it stands in the art-historians' game of who influenced whom.

Those things are important. But there's another way of looking at City Hall, or any building, a way with which architectural criticism currently is obsessed here and in England. This is the idea that a building communicates, that it has within it certain coded messages,

ARCHITECTURE By ROBERT CAMPBELL

intentional or not, that people read and understand.

These kinds of messages can be simple. For instance, pitched roofs, shutters, small-paned windows and chimneys all say: "I'm a house." At least they do in our culture. Leave off too many of those things and most people won't admit you've designed a house at all. "Looks like a factory," they sniff.

Modern buildings, sleek and bare, say proudly: "I was planned by reason and built by machines." At the opposite pole, hand-hewn boards and junkyard windows in a Vermont shack say, just as clearly: "My builder dropped out from rationalism, industrialism, regimentation. He believes in nature, in recycling, in doing for himself and probably in astrology."

Agree with them or not, such buildings are as full of rhetoric as a billboard. Buildings can't help talking.

That brings us back to Boston City Hall. Besides its other qualities, what if anything does it say?

If you ask the architects, Kallmann,



Mary Ann Chase has been named retail market development manager, a newly created post at Brookstone Co., a national mail order firm specializing in hard-to-find tools and gifts. John Sherman Breen of Plymouth has been appointed chief of the residential and commercial appraisal departments of the Jack Conway Co., South Shore real estate firm with 20 offices.

McKinnell and Knowles, they give you one message. They say City Hall is divided into layers like a sandwich, to communicate the parts of city government.

The top layer is the bureaucracy: Rows of identical windows that express the routine, office-work character of the city's many departments and the interchangeability of space and people here.

The bottom layer is the public part, made of red brick to tell us that this part of City Hall is part of the old city. This part welcomes the public into interior streets lined with the functions the public uses most, licensing, taxes and the like.

And the middle layer: That's the elected government, the mayor and council. Here the building's parts grow bigger, holder, thrust out into space to symbolize the relative importance of these functions.

Obviously, great care has been taken to express this complicated message, and most architects can read it because they've been told it's there. But all the evidence is that the general public neither reads nor cares about this message.

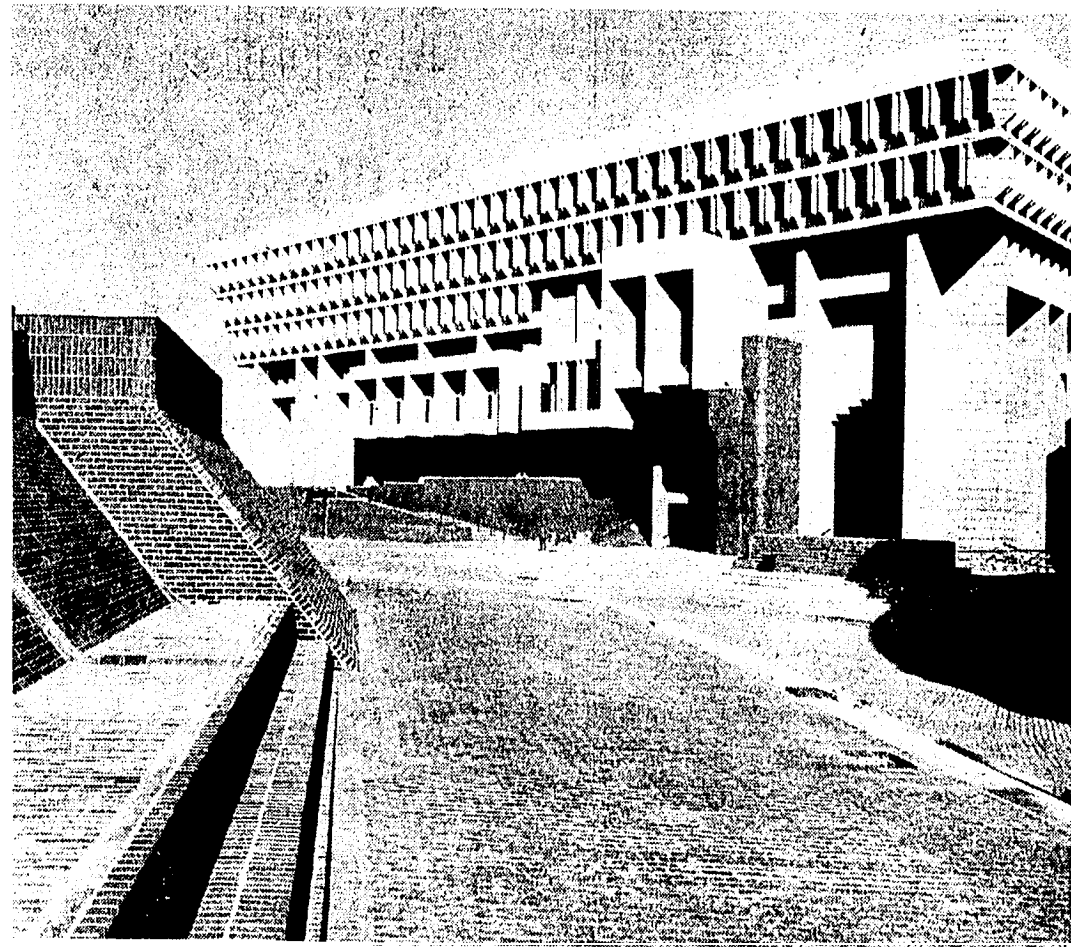
Then what message does the public get? It's hard to be sure. One series of street interviews conducted by a magazine a few years ago concluded that most Bostonians think City Hall speaks of Big Government — unwelcoming, fortresslike.

That makes at least two codes. There are many others. But most of them are as superficial as these two and fail to explain the powerful hold this building has even on people who don't like it.

I therefore suggest another message. This message can be put in the form of a short fable.

The fable goes like this:

Once upon a time there was a great and important building, probably the castle of a king, with huge pillars and a great, echoing entrance hall that was loud with music and festive with banners. Then came a time of troubles. War raged around the castle. The king fled. The castle was ravaged. Shells and bombs blasted out huge chunks of the building, leaving ragged, gaping holes. Decorations were stripped. The castle was left bare, broken but still standing.



Boston's City Hall — what does it say to you?

Civilization had collapsed. Out of the wreckage of their former homes, people came to huddle in the protection of the old ruined castle. They began to build new homes, small brick hovels tucked among the feet of the castle's great pillars, like the little houses fitted into the ruins of the palace of Diocletian at Split in Yugoslavia.

It's this message that accounts for City Hall's power. The building seems not merely to be there, but to have somehow survived, battered and beaten, but unbowed. It's message is simply this: "They could not tear me down." We respond to it as we respond to Lear, heroic precisely because of all he has endured.

It's a tragic kind of grandeur, and it's no wonder that not everyone finds the building very appealing.

City Hall shares part of its message

with at least one other architectural classic, Le Corbusier's famous monastery of La Tourette in France. There too the architect takes an obvious interest in making his building look like a ruin. But the differences are more important. Le Corbusier's building much smaller and placed in a pastoral setting, with grass growing on its roofs, seems to be crumbling gently into picturesque decay. City Hall is still fighting to survive.

City Hall isn't a simple building. It practically bristles with tensions and with messages, some garbled, trying to be heard. Of course, that's not the only thing the building is about. But it's more important in many ways than whether the elevators work.

Whether you agree with my fable or not, it's indicative of something very promising. That's the hope that if peo-

ple once again start to pay attention to what buildings are — or aren't — saying, then the built world will become meaningful again.

After 50 years in which most architects believed that meaning was the one thing you were supposed to leave out of buildings, that's cause for joy.

A lecture series on "Boston: Portrait of a Harbor" will be held at Old South Meeting House Thursdays in March. Inquiries may be made at Old South Meeting House, 310 Washington St., Boston 02108.

"Boston by Foot," an organization that runs walking tours of the city, needs guides and will train them in a series of April lectures (others may also attend). The director is Polly Flansburgh, Old Country Road, Lincoln.